and went on screaming until a servant ran in with an axe and chopped the cobra in half. Then my father's boss appeared with a shotgun and blew the cobra's head off. He told me it would be better not to say anything about this to my parents, so I never did. But from that day on I have lived in terror of snakes. Just thinking about it as I write these words is enough to make the hairs prickle on my scalp.

It follows that to think of the hooded Indian cobra *Naja naja* as death incarnate seems to me entirely reasonable. Recent research published by the American Society of Tropical Medicine and Hygiene has put the figure of deaths from snake-bite in India at forty-six thousand annually, which is a long way from the Government of India's official estimate of two thousand fatalities. Given such figures, it is easy to see why in India the cobra remains an object of fear – and of worship. Not only does it deliver death, it also disappears underground every summer, only to reappear with a new skin with the monsoon rains, seemingly reborn. So one can understand why it continues to be treated with as much reverence as caution – nowhere more so than among the Nairs in Kerala – and why the three great religions that took shape in early India all incorporated the cobra into their respective faiths.

My third memory is one of the last from my Indian childhood. My family were about to depart for Bombay (Mumbai) to board a troopship bound for Liverpool. On the morning of 31 January 1948 I paid my usual visit to the servants' quarters behind our bungalow, where I found everyone unusually subdued. The cook was crying. I asked why and was told that 'Bapu' had been killed. I had no idea who Bapu was but out of sympathy with the cook I began crying, too. But then I was told that there was no need to cry because Bapu was now sitting on a lotus leaf in Swarga (heaven) in the company of Lord Vishnu. That image of the assassinated Mahatma Gandhi seated on a lotus leaf with his spinning-wheel has stayed with me ever since.